Khrushchev knew that he could count on the sixty-three-year-old Malinovsky, a round-faced, burly, outspoken officer who had fought against Francisco Franco during the Spanish Civil War and whom he had met during World War II. Malinovsky had distinguished himself at Stalingrad, led the Soviet army groups liberating his native Ukraine, and ended his service in Europe by capturing Vienna. Khrushchev had chosen Malinovsky to replace the independent-minded Georgii Zhukov as minister of defense in 1957, and thereafter Malinovsky had become his closest ally in the painful reform of the armed forces. They were significantly reduced in numbers, with funds redirected from the traditional services to the newborn missile forces.[5]

Malinovsky ordered Colonel General Ivanov, the secretary of the Defense Council and chief of the Main Operations Directorate of the General Staff, who had attended the May 21 meeting with Khrushchev, to prepare the proposal for execution. When Ivanov returned to his headquarters after the meeting of the Defense Council, one of his subordinates, the forty-three-year-old curly-haired Major General Anatoly Gribkov, realized right away that something extraordinary had happened. “I had long known my direct superior, but this was the first time that I saw him so agitated,” recalled Gribkov. Ivanov gave Gribkov the notes he had made at the meeting. He wanted the young general to turn them into a draft proposal for the deployment operation. The assignment was so secret that only two others would work on the plan under Gribkov’s command. Clerical support was ruled out as well. “No typist is to be involved,” ordered Ivanov. “Except for you three, no one is to know of the document.”[6]

The task was not only secret but urgent. “Forgetting all about time, we set to work,” recalled Gribkov years later. The seven-page draft was ready in two days. Gribkov and his subordinates proposed sending to Cuba a total of 44,000 officers and soldiers, as well as 1,300 civilians—an impressive number of people, to be accompanied by an equally impressive amount of weaponry, equipment, and supplies. According to Gribkov’s estimate, some seventy or eighty cargo and passenger ships would be required to take them to Cuba. The Group of Soviet Forces in Cuba, as the new task force was officially called, was to be drawn from all branches of the armed forces—